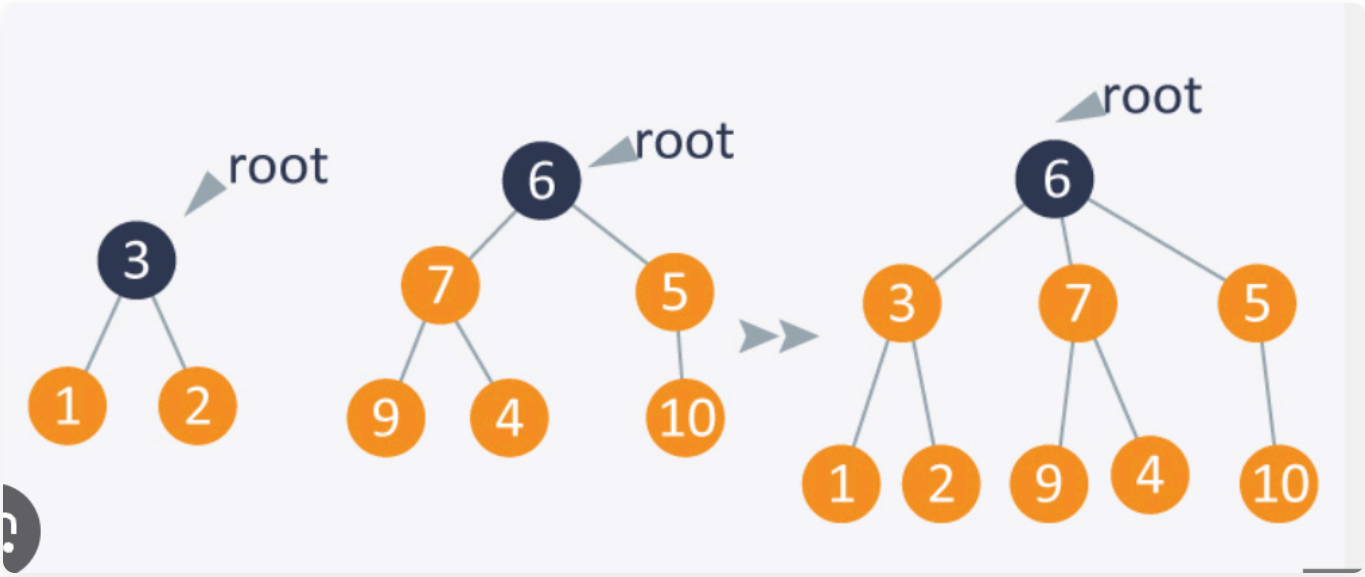
Disjoint Set Union (DSU)

Disjoint Set Unions (DSUs) are used to find which elements belong to the same group. This data structure enables the merging of separate sets and addressing different inquiries concerning them, such as determining if elements a and b belong to the same set and finding out the size of the set.

Two sets are called disjoint sets if they don't have any element in common. The disjoint set data structure is used to store such sets. DSU maintains a collection of separate sets, or groups which are represented by trees. Each group has a representative element called its root or representative.



In DSU, two main operations can be performed: - Find, finding representative of a disjoint set. For example, if we want to find the group of C, we need to follow the parent pointers to the root. Suppose we have, C points to B and B points to A. From this, we know that C belongs to the group represented by A. - Union, merging two disjoint sets to a single set. For example, A and B are two different groups. B points to A, hence we perform the union operation on them. Both groups now share the representative of A. However, we need to keep in mind, the union operation merges groups, but it does not necessarily connect the exact two elements directly. It

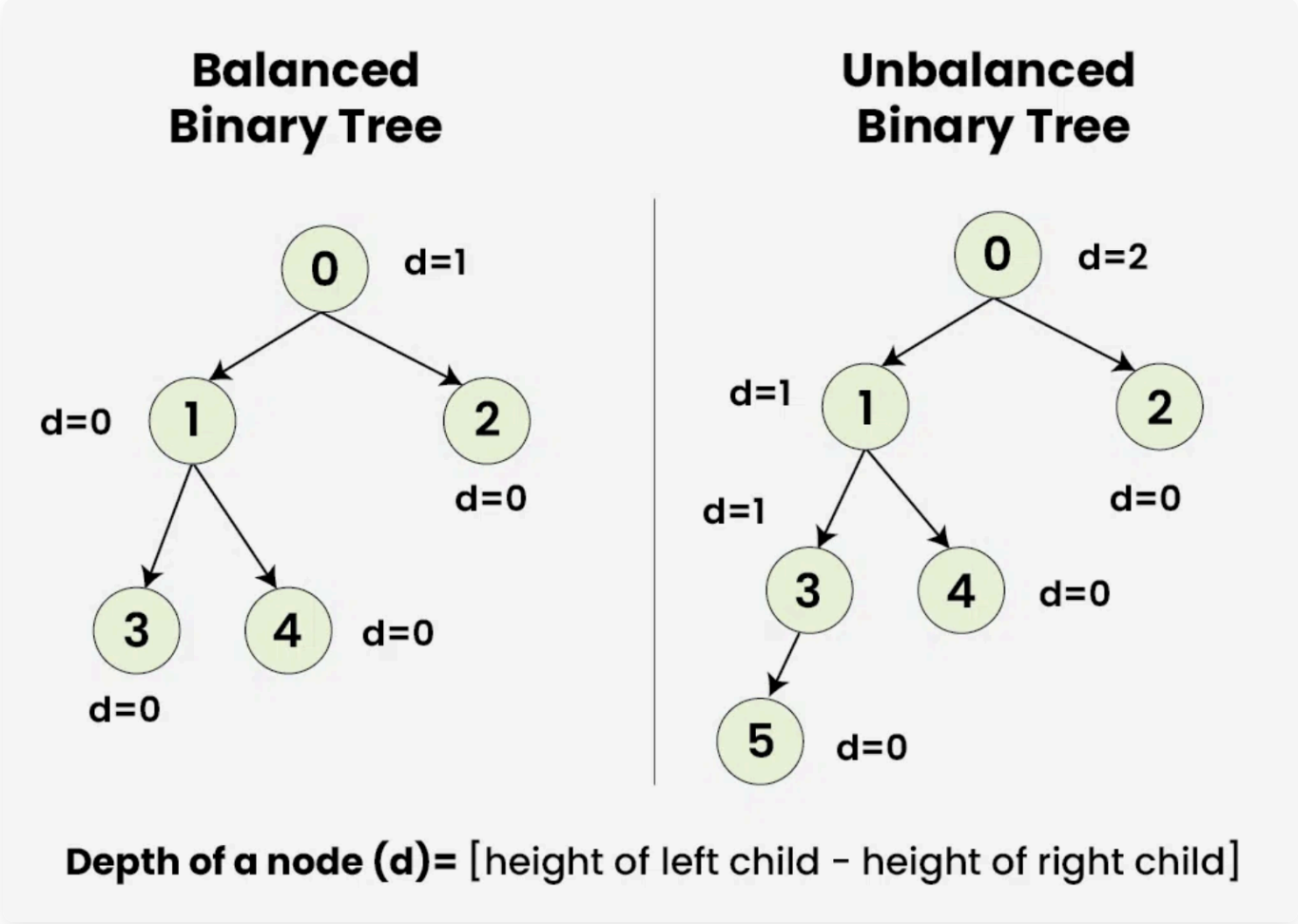
merges the sets that contain them.

Optimisations can help DSU to be more efficient: - Path compression When finding an element's root, make the elements encountered point directly to that root. For example, D->C->B->A can be shortened to just D->A. - Union by size or rank When merging two groups, attach the smaller or shallower tree to the larger or taller one. This helps prevent unnecessarily long chains.

Balanced Search Trees (BST)

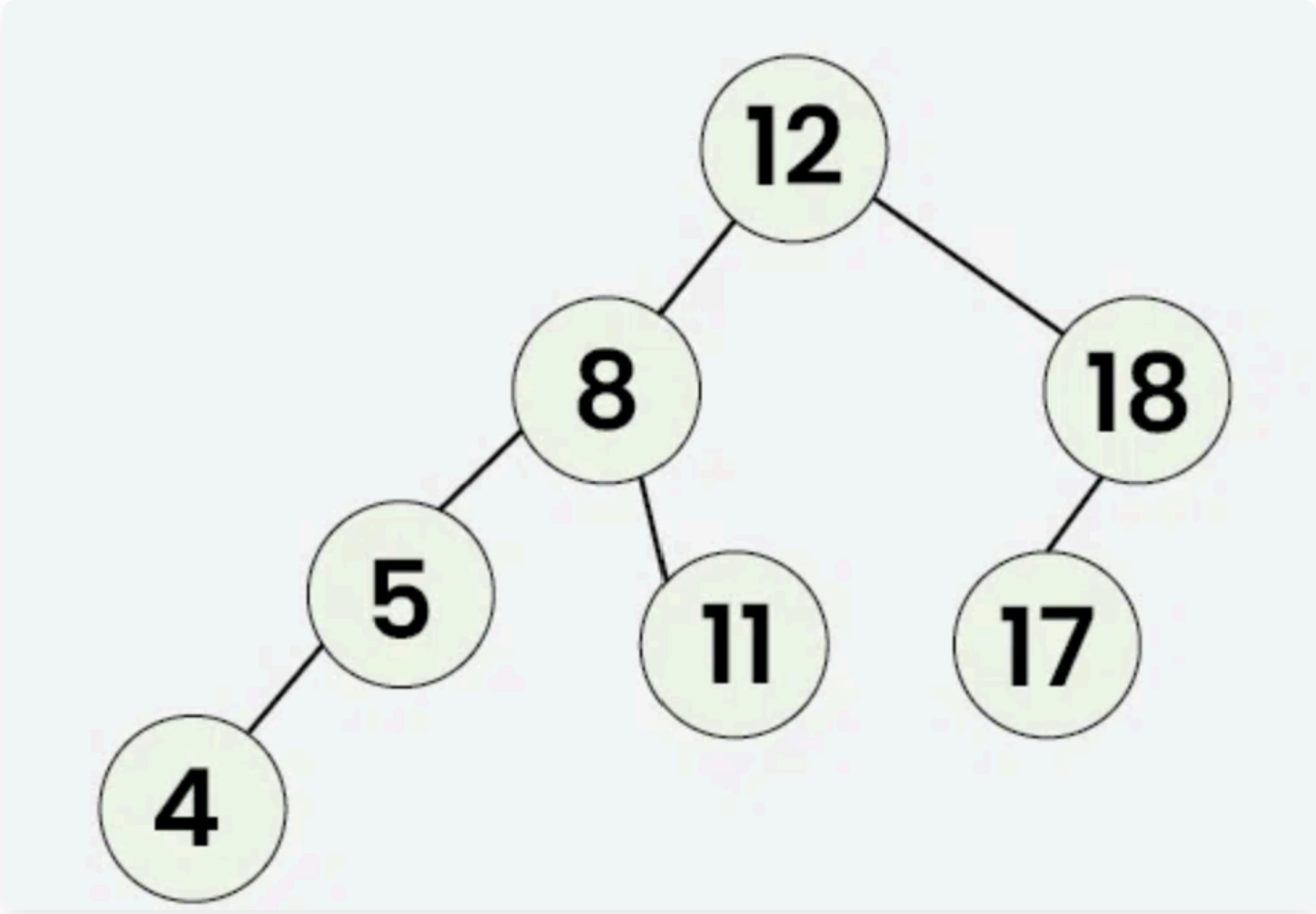
Binary Search Trees (BSTs) organizes values based on three rules: - Values smaller than a node go to its left. - Values larger than a node go to its right. - Each node has at most two children.

However, BSTs aren't always well-shaped or divided properly. Unbalanced BSTs can make search times much longer than it has to be, that is why Balanced Search Trees tries to keep the tree's height small. When a tree becomes unbalanced, it rearranges its nodes while still following the BST rules.

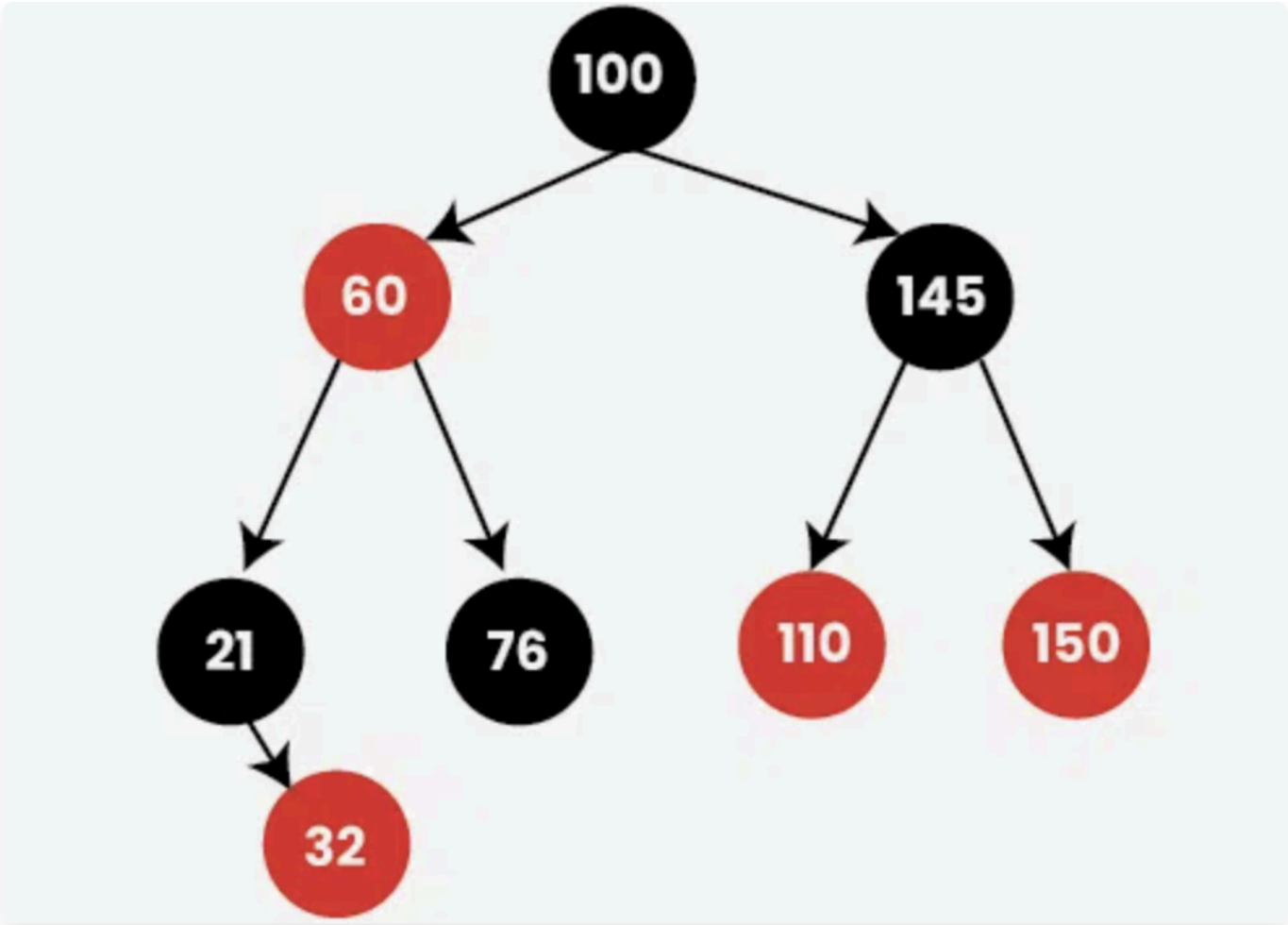


There are three conditions to check if a Binary Search Tree is balanced: - The absolute difference between heights of left and right subtrees at any node should be less than or equal to 1. - For each node, its left subtree should be a balanced binary tree. - For each node, its right subtree should be a balanced binary tree.

There are two well-known self-balancing BSTs: - AVL Trees, where the difference between heights of left and right subtrees cannot be more than one for all nodes.



- Red-Black Tree, where each node has an additional attribute: a color, which can be either red or black. The primary objective of these trees is to maintain balance during insertions and deletions, ensuring efficient data retrieval and manipulation.



References: - https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/dsa/introduction-to-disjoint-set-data-structure-or-union-find-algorithm/ - https://www.w3schools.com/dsa/dsa_data_binarytrees.php - https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/dsa/balanced-binary-tree/

1.1 Foundations of Algorithms and Data Structures

1. Core Concepts

What is an Algorithm?

An **algorithm** is a step-by-step computational procedure designed to transform a given set of inputs into a predictable outputs. It acts as a systematic tool for solving specific computational problems by detailing the exact operations a computer must perform.

Key characteristics of an algorithm include: * **Input:** Zero or more defined values or datasets provided to the algorithm. * **Output:** One or more results corresponding to the calculated inputs. * **Definiteness:** Every step must be clear, unambiguous, and precisely specified. * **Finiteness:** The procedure must terminate after a finite number of steps for all valid inputs to avoid endless loop. * **Effectiveness:** Each operation must be basic, practical, and feasible enough to be executed using available resources. * **Generality:** It should be able to solve an entire class of problems with varied inputs, rather than just one specific case. * **Language Independence:** An algorithm is a conceptual plan; it is independent of any specific programming language and can be written in pseudocode, flowcharts, or plain prose.

2. Formal Problem Statements and Problem Instances

To analyze an algorithm mathematically, a computational problem must be formally stated in terms of its required input and desired output properties.

Example: The Sorting Problem

* **Input:** A sequence of n numbers represented as: $$\langle a_1, a_2, \dots, a_n \rangle$$

* **Output:** A reordering (permutation) of the input sequence such that the elements satisfy the ordering relationship: $$a'_1 \le a'_2 \le \dots \le a'_n$$

Instance of a Problem

A **problem instance** refers to a specific set of input data that satisfies all constraints defined by the problem statement. * **Example Input Instance:** $$\langle 31, 41, 59, 26, 41, 58 \rangle$$ * **Expected Output Instance:** $$\langle 26, 31, 41, 41, 58, 59 \rangle$$

3. Algorithm Correctness and Efficiency

Correctness

An algorithm is considered **correct** if, for every valid input instance, it eventually halts and produces the exact specified output. * **Incorrect Algorithms:** Algorithms that either fail to terminate (enter an infinite loop) or halt with an invalid result. * **Controlled Error Rates:** In specific specialized domains (such as probabilistic primality testing or randomized search), algorithms with small, mathematically bounded error rates can still be practical and useful.

Efficiency

Algorithm efficiency measures how well an algorithm utilizes computational resourcesâ€”primarily time and memoryâ€”as the scale of the problem increases. An algorithm must be efficient enough to execute within acceptable time and resource limits. When selecting or analyzing an algorithm, efficiency is governed by several core factors such as input size (n) and the volume of data being processed. As n grows, the execution time or memory footprint changes according to the algorithm's growth rate. There is also initial structures which also affect the extent to which the data is already organized or formatted prior to processing. For example, sorting an already sorted array takes far fewer operations than sorting a completely randomized array.

Selecting the Right Algorithm

Choosing the optimal algorithm for a given task depends on several trade-offs: 1. **Input Size:** The volume of data (n) being processed. 2. **Initial Structure:** The extent to which the data is already organized or partially sorted. 3. **Hardware Constraints:** Available main memory (RAM), storage bandwidth, and CPU architecture.

4. What is a Data Structure?

A **data structure** is a specialized format for organizing, managing, and storing data in memory so that specific operationsâ€”such as access, insertion, deletion, and searchingâ€”can be executed efficiently.

5. Modern Computing and Parallelism

Historically, performance improvements relied on increasing single-core processor clock speeds. Due to physical power and thermal limitations, modern processor architectures rely heavily on **multi-core designs**.

To maximize computational performance on multi-core hardware, algorithms must be designed with **parallelism** in mind, breaking down tasks into independent threads that execute concurrently across multiple processing units.

1.2 Correctness Complexity

1. Algorithm Correctness

What is algorithm correctness

An algorithm is correct if it produces the expected output for every valid input. This breaks down into two levels: * **Partial Correctness:** If the algorithm finishes running, the output is guaranteed to be correct. * **Total Correctness:** The algorithm is partially correct and it is mathematically guaranteed to teminate (it will nver get stuck in an infinite loop).

To prove correctness, computer scientists use structural logic: * **Preconditions and Postconditions:** The state that must exist before the algorithm runs and the state guaranteed after it finishes must be true. * **Loop Invariants:** A property that remains true before, during, and after every iteration of a loop. Proving an invariant usually relies on mathematical induction. * **Variants:** A quantitative measure that strictly decreases during every loop iteration. When it reaches a baseline (like zero), the loop stops, guaranteeing termination.

2. Algorithm Complexity

What is algorithm complexity?

Complexity abstracts away specific hardware speeds to measure how an algorithm's resource consumption scales as the input size (n) grows. * **Time Complexity:** The number of basic operations (comparisons, assignments, arithmetic) executed. * **Space Complexity:** The amount of auxiliary memory required beyond the input itself.

3. The Role of Data Structures

Algorithms and data structures are inseparable because the layout of the data directly dictates the complexity bounds.

Complexity Trade-offs

* If you need $O(1)$ constant time lookups, you might choose a Hash Table, but you sacrifice memory to get it. * If you need memory efficiency and strictly ordered data, you might use a Binary Search Tree, which slows lookups to $O(\log n)$.

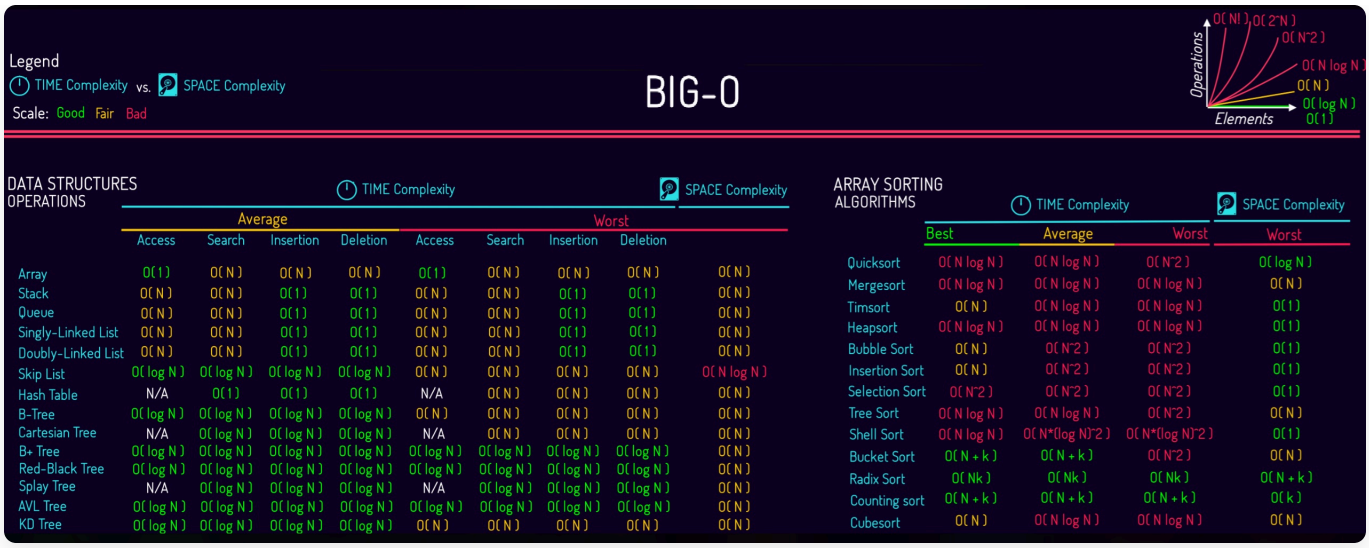
Structural Correctness

Data structures maintain their own invariants. For example, a Max-Heap must always guarantee that every parent node is greater than its children. If an insertion algorithm temporarily breaks this invariant, it must restore it before completing. If it fails, the data structure is no longer structurally "correct," and its efficiency guarantees collapse.

4. Asymptotic Notation (Big O)

We use Asymptotic Notation to categorize this scaling into bounds: Big O for the worst-case upper bound, Big Omega for the best-case lower bound, and Big Theta for a tight bound.

This graph below show the best-case and worst-case based on the complexity for data structures and algorithms:



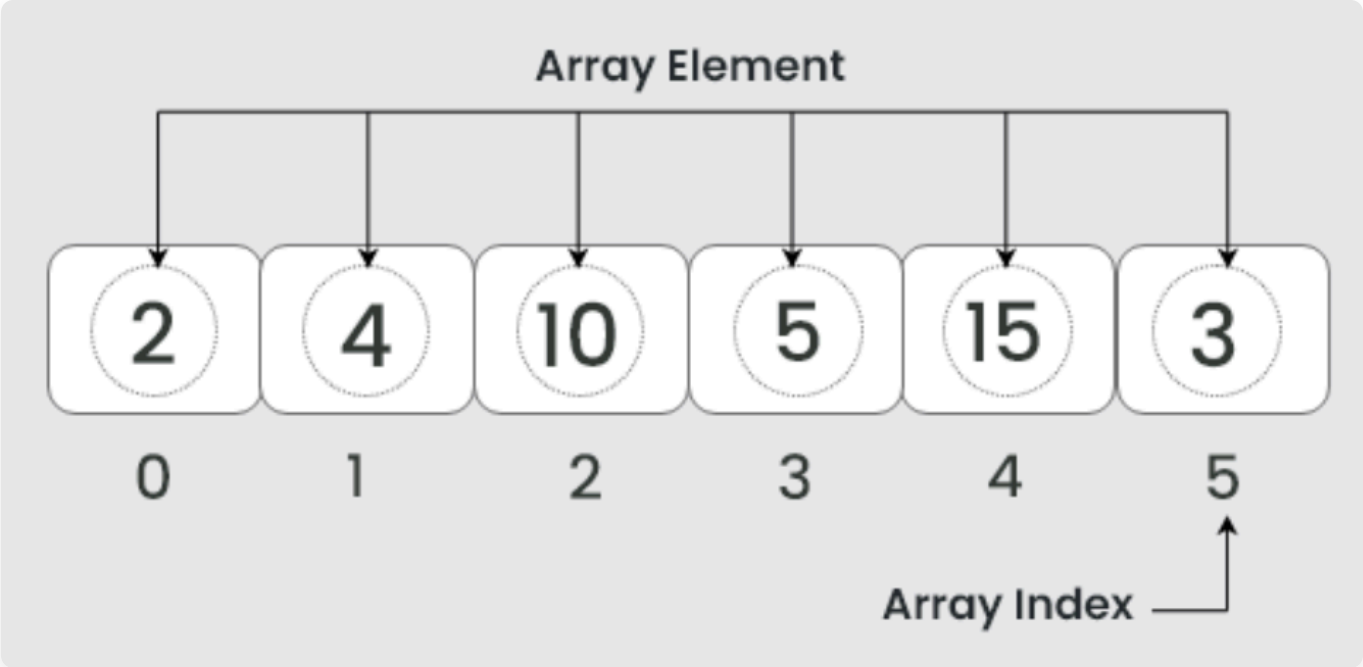
1.3 Arrays and Dynamic Arrays

1. Arrays

What is array

An **array** is a foundational data structure that stores a collection of elements in a linked block of memory. Because the memory is linked together, the computer can instantly calculate the exact memory address of any element using a simple mathematical offset, making retrieval lightning-fast.

Visualisation:



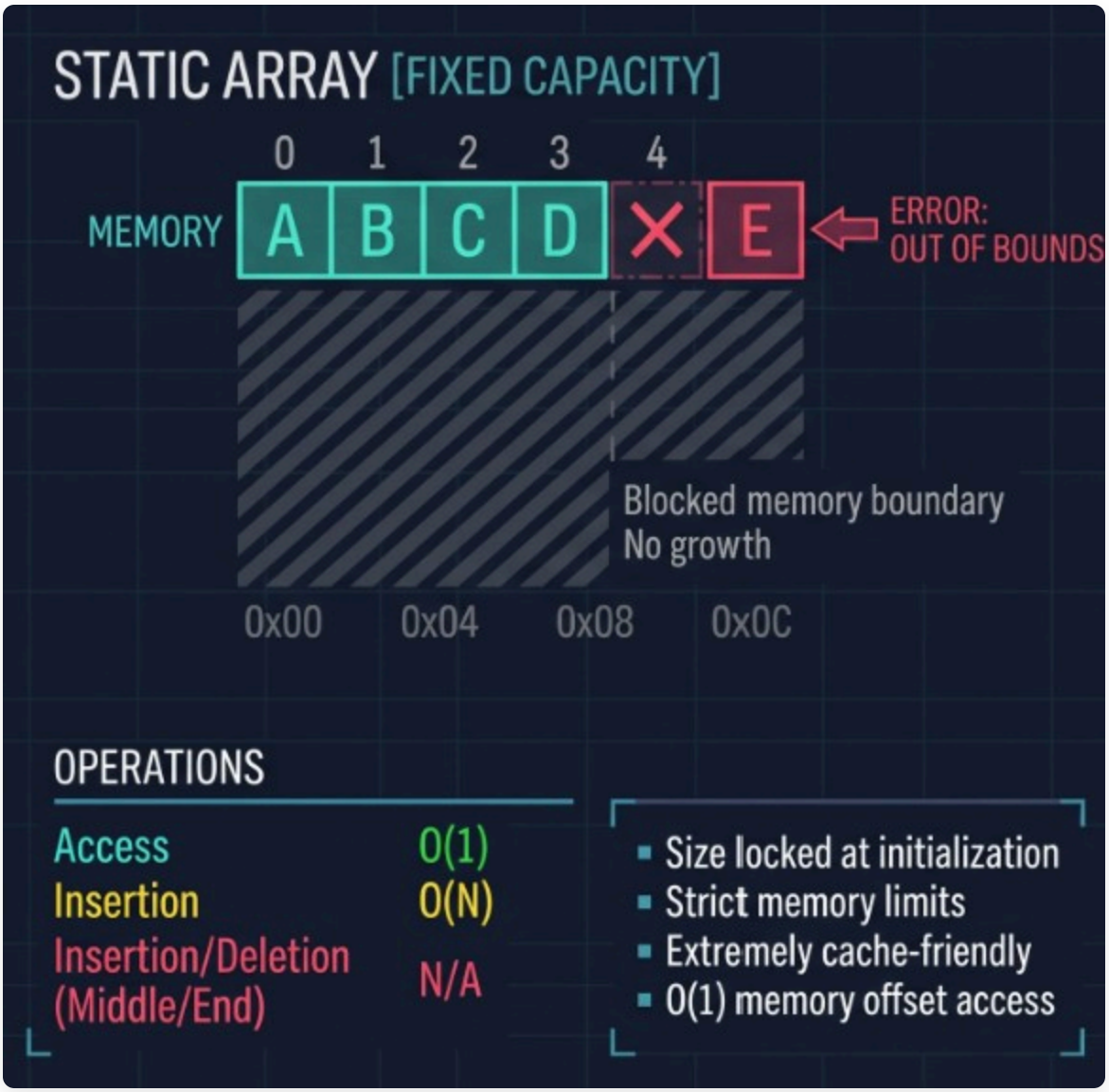
1. Standard (Static) Arrays

When you create a standard array (like in C or Java), you must declare its size upfront. The operating system allocates exactly that amount of linked together memory and nothing more.

Key Characteristics:

* **Fast Access (`O(1)`):** Accessing an element by index (e.g., `array[3]`) takes `O(1)` time. The computer simply takes the base memory address and adds `3 * (element size)`. * **Cache Friendliness:** Because elements are stored right next to each other, processors can load chunks of the array into the CPU cache simultaneously, making iteration extremely fast. * **The Limitation:** Static arrays cannot grow. If you declare an array of size 10 and need to add an 11th element, you cannot simply append itâ€”the memory space immediately following your array might already be occupied by another program.

Visualisation:



2. Dynamic Arrays

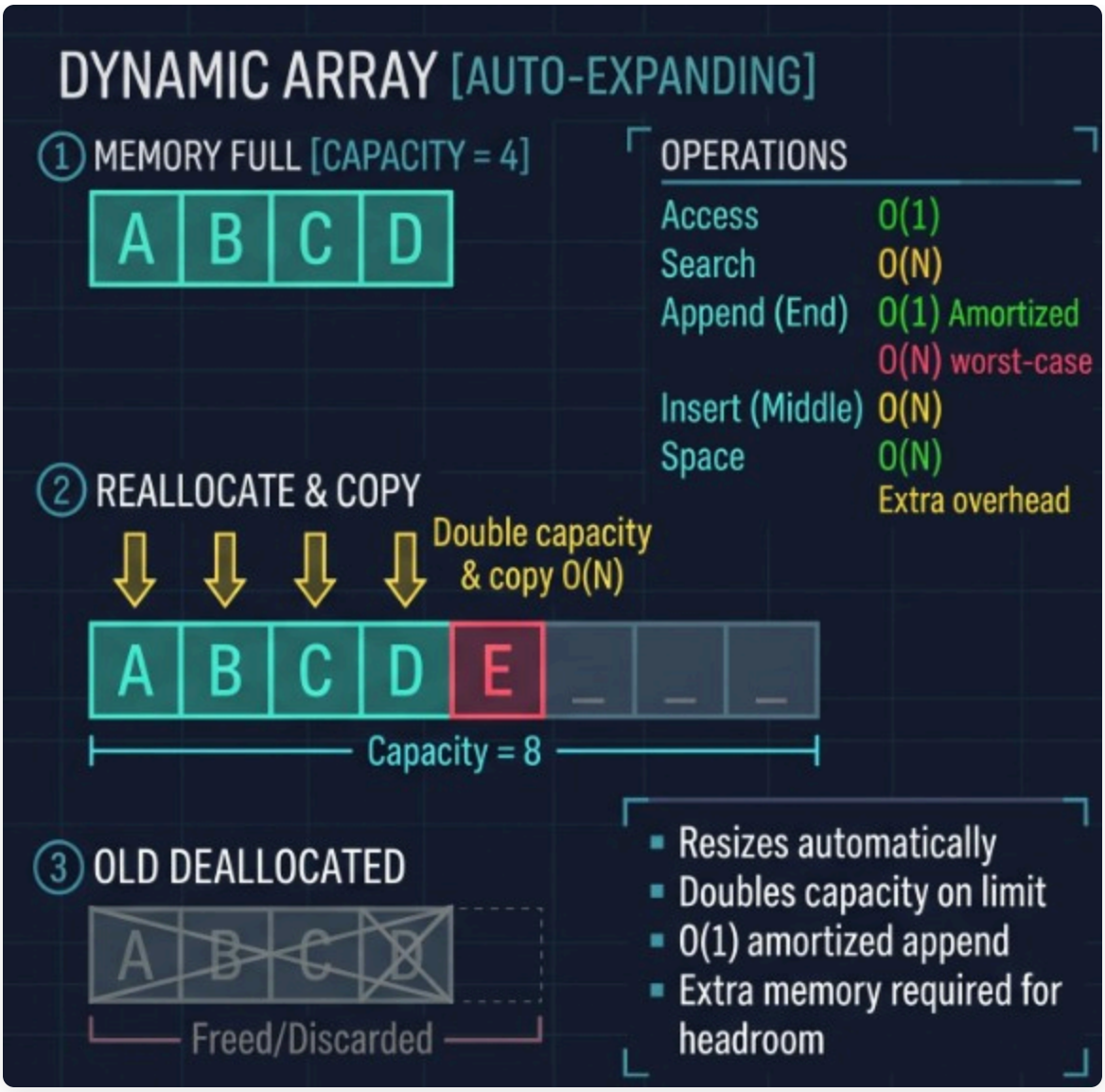
Dynamic arrays (like `list` in Python, `std::vector` in C++, or `ArrayList` in Java) solve the size limitation of static arrays while preserving their fast `O(1)` indexing. They achieve this by managing a static array behind the scenes and automatically resizing it when it gets full.

The Resizing Mechanism:

1. **Initialization:** The dynamic array starts with an underlying static array of a small fixed capacity (e.g., capacity of 4). 2. **Insertion:** As you append elements, it fills up the available slots. 3. **Capacity Reached:** When you try to add an element but the capacity is full, the dynamic array creates a *new*, larger static array in memory (typically doubling the size, e.g., from 4 to 8). 4. **Copy and Swap:** It copies all existing elements from the old array into the new one, adds your new element, and then frees the old array's memory.

Because resizing happens infrequently (e.g., at sizes 4, 8, 16, 32...), the heavy cost of copying elements is spread out over many cheap insertions. This makes the **amortized time complexity** for appending an element `O(1)`.

Visualisation:



3. Time Complexity Comparison

| Operation | Static Array | Dynamic Array | | :--- | :--- | :--- | | **Access (Index)** | `O(1)` | `O(1)` | | **Append (End)** | N/A (Fixed size) | `O(1)` Amortized* | | **Insert/Delete (Middle)**| `O(n)` | `O(n)` | | **Search (Unsorted)** | `O(n)` | `O(n)` |

**The worst-case for a single append in a dynamic array is `O(n)` if a resize is triggered, but it averages to `O(1)` over time.*

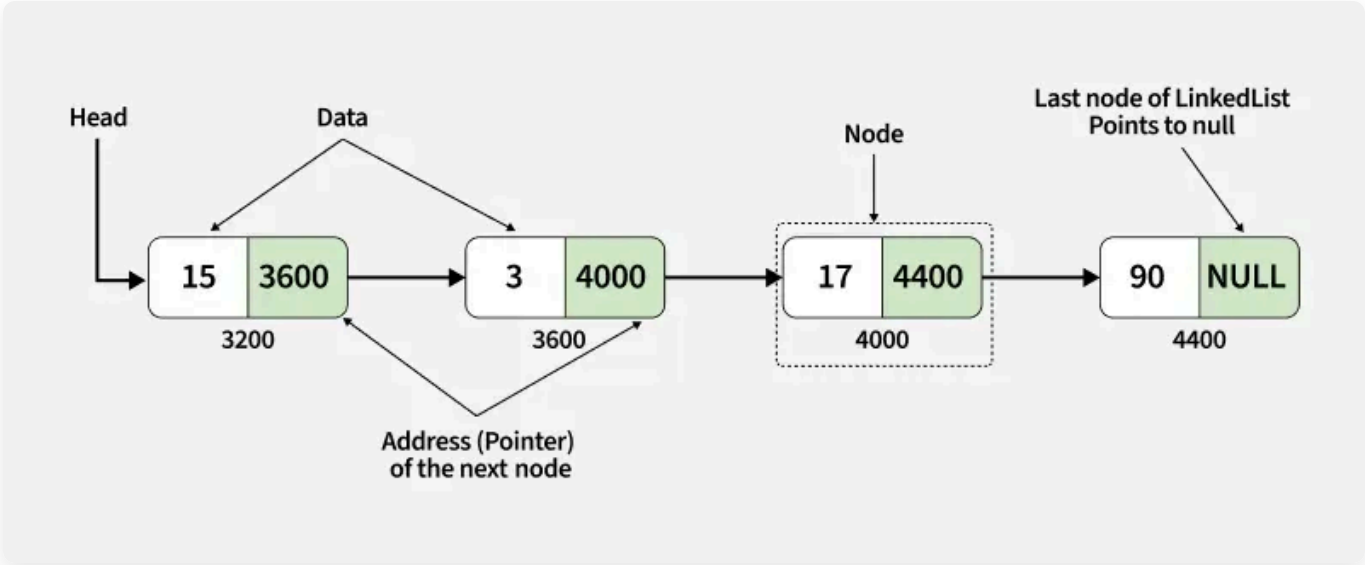
1.4 Linked Lists

1. Introduction to Linked Lists

A linked list is a foundational linear data structure where elements (referred to as nodes) are stored in non-linked memory locations.

Unlike arrays, which store elements in a continuous block of memory, the elements of a linked list are connected via pointers (or references). Each node typically consists of two components: * **Data:** The actual value you want to store (e.g., an integer, string, or object). * **Next (Pointer):** A reference pointing to the memory address of the next node in the sequence.

Visualisation:

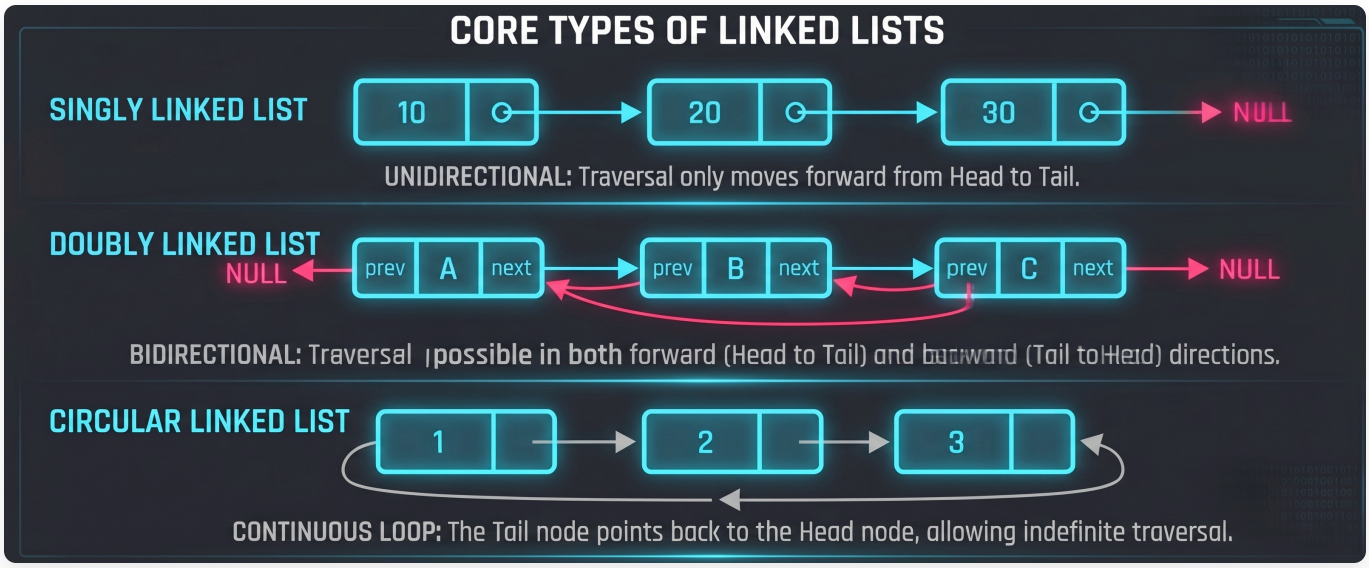


2. Core Types of Linked Lists

Types of Linked Lists:

* **Singly Linked List:** The most basic type. Each node points only to the next node. Traversal can only move in a single direction (forward from the head to the tail). * **Doubly Linked List:** Each node contains two pointers: one pointing to the next node and another pointing to the previous node. This allows bidirectional traversal (both forward and backward). * **Circular Linked List:** The last node points back to the first node instead of pointing to `null`, forming a continuous loop. This can be implemented as either singly or doubly linked.

Visualisation:



3. Key Operations and Performance

Because linked lists manage memory differently than arrays, their performance characteristics vary significantly depending on the operation:

| Operation | Singly Linked List | Array or Dynamic Array | | :--- | :--- | :--- | | **Access (by index)** | $O(n)$ â€” Must traverse sequentially | $O(1)$ â€” Direct memory lookup | | **Insertion or Deletion at Head** | $O(1)$ â€” Instant pointer update | $O(n)$ â€” Requires shifting elements | | **Insertion or Deletion at Tail** | $O(n)$ (or $O(1)$ if tail pointer is tracked) | $O(1)$ amortized | | **Search (by value)** | $O(n)$ | $O(n)$ (unsorted) / $O(\log n)$ (sorted binary search) |

4. Advantages and Disadvantages

Advantages:

* **Dynamic Size:** They can easily grow or shrink in size at runtime, avoiding the fixed-size limitations of static arrays. * **Efficient Insertions or Deletions:** Adding or removing items doesn't require shifting elements around in memory; you simply update the pointer references.

Disadvantages:

* **No Random Access:** You cannot access the i-th element directly. To find an element, you must start from the head node and traverse through every preceding node * **Memory Overhead:** Each node requires extra memory to store the pointer(s) in addition to the data itself. * **Poor Cache Locality:** Because nodes are scattered across memory rather than stored in linked, CPU caching is less efficient compared to arrays.

Outline:

- Basic concept: - Stacks: last in, first out (LIFO) - Queue: first in, first out (FIFO)

Definition:

Stacks and queues are two ways to store items. They differ in one rule: which item you take out first. A stack removes the newest item first, while a queue removes the oldest item first. Both can use an array, where markers (top for a stack, head and tail for a queue) track where to add and remove, so no items have to be moved. - Stacks: Add (Push) & Remove (Pop) - Queue: Add (Enqueue) & Remove (Dequeue)

Easy Analogy:

- Stack: a pile of plates. You put a clean plate on top, and you also take a plate from the top. The last plate placed is the first one taken. - Queue: a line at a cashier. The person who arrived first is served first, and new people join at the back.

Key Terms

| Term | Meaning | | ---------- | ---------- | | Top | The end of a stack where items are added and removed. It holds the newest item. | | Push | Add an item to the top of a stack.| | Pop | Remove the top item of a stack and return it.| | Front | The end of a queue where items are removed. It holds the oldest item.| | Back | The end of a queue where items are added. It holds the newest item. | | Enqueue | Add an item to the back of a queue. | | Dequeue | Remove the front item of a queue and return it. | | Marker | A number that remembers a position in an array | | Head | The marker for the front of a queue. It points to the oldest item, the next one to be removed. | | Tail | The marker for where the next new item will go. It points to the empty spot just after the newest item. |

Worked Example:

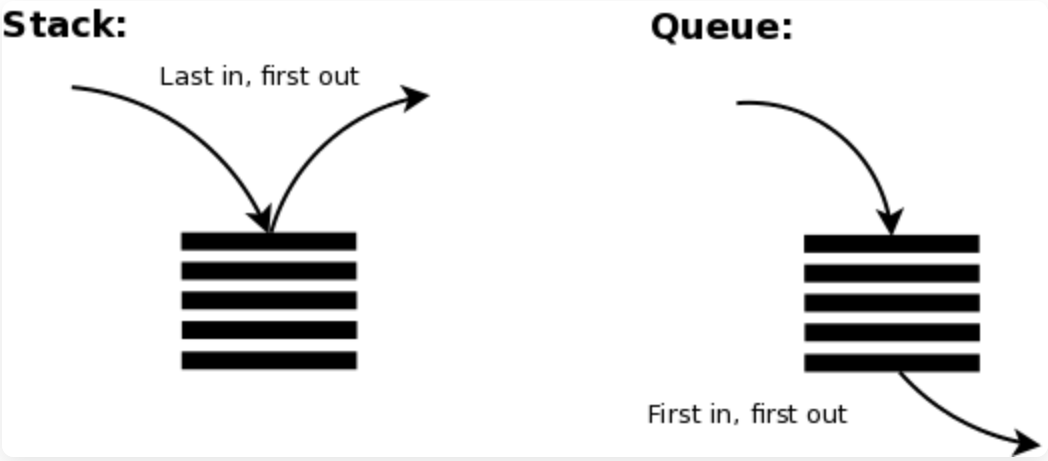
- Stack example (last in, first out)

| Step | Action | Stack (left = bottom, right = top) | Removed | | ---------- | ---------- | ---------- | ---------- | |1|Push 5|5|| |2|Push 3|5,3|| |3|Push 6|5,3,6|| |4|Pop|5,3|6| |5|Push 4|5,3,4|| |6|Pop|5,3|4| |7|Pop|5|3|

- Queue example (first in, first out)

| Step | Action | Queue (left = front, right = back) | Removed | | ---------- | ---------- | ---------- | ---------- | |1|Enqueue 5|5|| |2|Enqueue 3|5,3|| |3|Enqueue 6|5,3,6|| |4|Dequeue|3,6|5| |5|Enqueue 4|3,6,4|| |6|Dequeue|6,4|3| |7|Dequeue|4|6|

Visual:



Stack: items enter and leave at the same end. Queue: items enter at the back and leave from the front. https://gohighbrow.com/wp-content/uploads/2018/07/Computer-science-fundamentals_6.1.png

Question exercise & Answer:

| Step | Action | | ------|----- | |1|Add 5| |2|Add 8| |3|Remove one item| |4|Add 2| |5|Add 9| |6|Remove one item|

1. Which items are removed in the stack, and what is left? - (8 and 9 are removed) & (5,2 remained) 2. Which items are removed in the queue, and what is left? - (5 and 8 are removed) & (2,9 remained) 3. Which structure would you use to model a line of people at a bank, and why? - Queue, because first come first served. The one who waits the longest will be served first.

References:

1. Cormen, T. H., Leiserson, C. E., Rivest, R. L., & Stein, C. (2009). Introduction to Algorithms (3rd ed.). MIT Press. Â§10.1, pp. 232â€“236. 2. https://fahadsultan.com/csc122/data/stacks_queues.html

Outline:

- Recursion vs. loops. A loop finishes a set of steps and then repeats it. Recursion repeats the steps as a subtask of itself. The situation that is small enough to answer directly, so the repeating stops. For example, a list with no items, or a list with only one item.

- Divide-and-Conquer - Some problems are too big to solve in one go. D&C breaks them into smaller copies of the same problem. - It works in three steps: divide, conquer, combine. - It uses recursion to solve the smaller parts.

Definition:

Recursion is solving a task by repeating the same steps on a smaller version of the same task, until the task is small enough to answer directly. In other words, it is a procedure that refers to itself to solve a smaller version of the problem. Divide-and-Conquer is a way to solve a big problem by splitting it into smaller problems of the same kind, solving each small one, and then joining the answers. - Divide: split the problem into smaller parts that look like the original. - Conquer: solve each part by using the same method again (recursion). If a part is small enough, just solve it directly. - Combine: put the small answers together into the answer to the big problem.

Easy Analogy:

- Recursion - The â€œhigher or lowerâ€ guessing game. - Your friend thinks of a number from 1 to 100. - You guess 50. Your friend says â€œhigherâ€. - Now you only need to look at 51â€“100, so you guess 75. - Each guess cuts the possibilities in half, and you repeat the same idea each time.

- Divide-and-Conquer - Sorting a pile of exam papers: - Split the pile into two smaller piles. - Ask two friends to sort one pile each. - Join the two sorted piles into one: look at the top paper of each pile, take the one that comes first, and repeat.

Worked Example:

- Recursion. Task: Find 27 in this sorted list: 3, 8, 12, 15, 21, 27, 34, 40. 1. If the list is empty â†’ the number is not here. Stop. 2. Otherwise, look at the middle number. (If the list has an even number of entries, the middle is the first entry of the second half.) - If it matches â†’ found it. Stop. - If your number is smaller â†’ search the first half, using these same steps. - If your number is bigger â†’ search the second half, using these same steps.|

|Step|List|Middle|What Happens| |---|---|---|---| |1|3,8,12,15,21,27,34,40|21|27 is bigger, so keep the right half| |2|27,34,40|34|27 is smaller, so keep the left half| |3|27|27|Found it!|

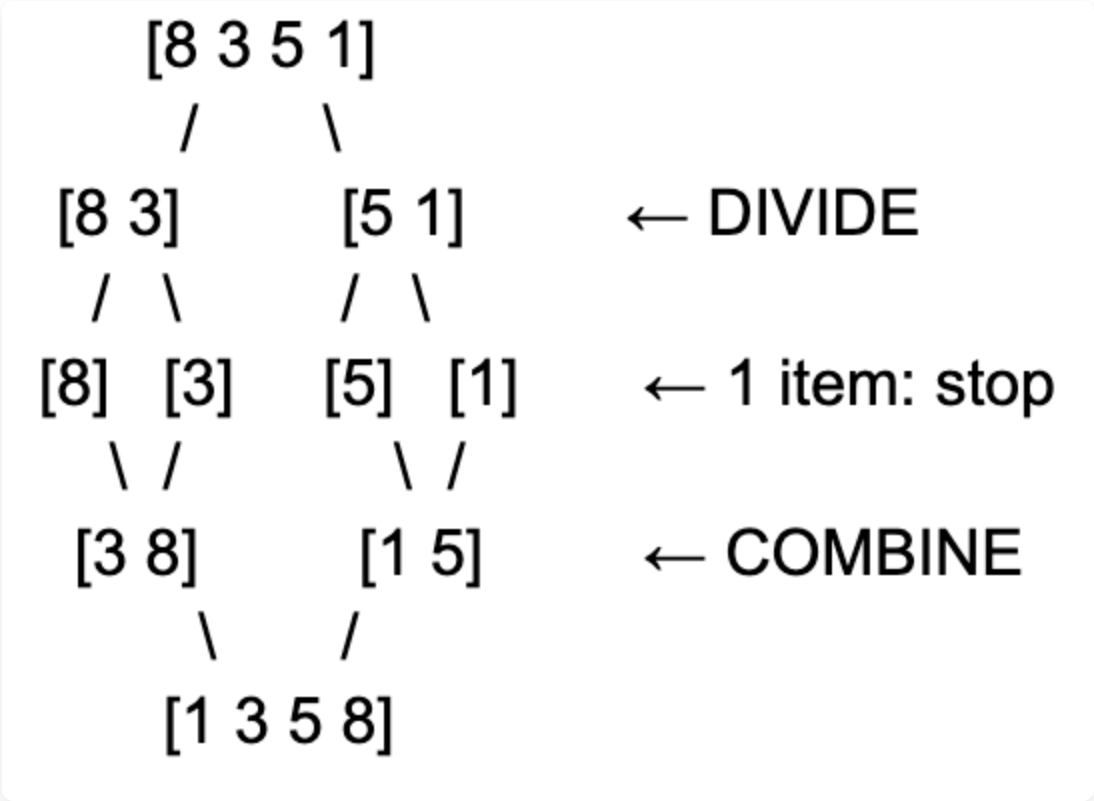
- Divide-and-Conquer. sort 8, 3, 5, 1

|Step|What Happens|Result| |---|---|---| |Divide|Split the list in half|[8, 3] and [5, 1]| |Divide|Split again until each part has 1 item|[8], [3], [5], [1]| |Conquer|One item is already sorted, so stop splitting|| |Combine|Merge [8] and [3]|[3, 8]| |Combine|Merge [5] and [1]|[1, 5]| |Combine|Merge [3, 8] and [1, 5]|[1, 3, 5, 8]|

- Compare 3 and 1. Take 1. - Compare 3 and 5. Take 3. - Compare 8 and 5. Take 5. - Only 8 are

left. Take 8.

Visual:



Question exercise & Answer:

- Use the sorted list 2, 6, 10, 14, 19, 23, 30. 1. Search for 23. Which middle numbers do you check? - The list has 7 entries, so the middle is the 4th entry. - Check 14. 23 is bigger, so keep 19, 23, 30. - Check 23. Found after 2 checks.

2. Search for 5. What happens? - Check 14. 5 is smaller, so keep 2, 6, 10. - Check 6. 5 is smaller, so keep 2. - Check 2. 5 is bigger, but nothing is left on the right side - The list becomes empty, so 5 is not in the list.

3. What is the stopping rule (base case) in this search? - The search stops when the list is empty (not found) or when the middle number matches (found).

- Use the sorted list 6, 2, 9, 4 1. Sort 6, 2, 9, 4 with merge sort. Show each step. - Divide: [6, 2] and [9, 4], then [6], [2], [9], [4]. - Combine: [6] + [2] â†' [2, 6]. [9] + [4] â†' [4, 9]. - Last merge: compare 2 and 4, take 2. Compare 6 and 4, take 4. Compare 6 and 9, take 6. Then take 9. - Result: [2, 4, 6, 9].

2. What are the three steps of Divide-and-Conquer? - Divide, Conquer, Combine.

3. How is merge sort different from binary search? - Merge sort solves both halves and then combines them. Binary search keeps only one half and has no combined step.

References:

1. Brookshear, J. Glenn. Computer Science: An Overview, 11th ed. (2011). Â§5.5 â€œRecursive Structuresâ€□, pp. 214-221; pseudocode in Figure 5.14, p. 216. 2. Cormen et al. Introduction to Algorithms, 3rd ed. Â§2.3.1 â€œThe divide-and-conquer approachâ€□, pp. 30-31.

Outline:

A hash table is a way to store items so we can add, find, and delete them quickly. A rule called a hash function turns each itemâ€™s key into a slot number. Sometimes two keys get the same slot, which is called a collision, and chaining fixes this by keeping a list in each slot.

Definition:

A hash table stores items in numbered slots, and a hash function decides which slot each key goes to. One simple hash function is k mod m, which means â€œthe remainder when the key k is divided by the number of slots mâ€. When two keys land in the same slot (a collision), chaining keeps them together in a list in that slot. Searching is usually very fast, because we go straight to one slot, but it is slow in the worst case, when all keys land in the same slot.

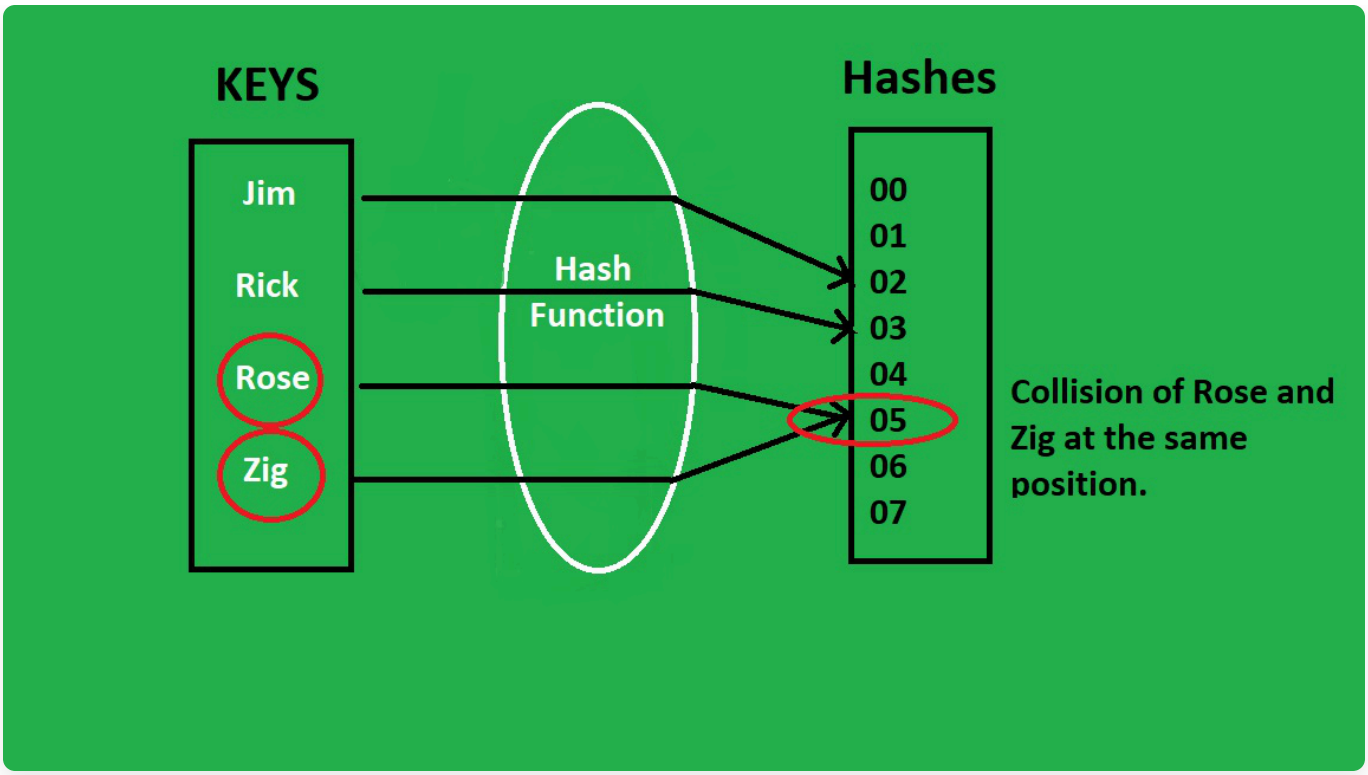
Easy Analogy:

1. A shoe rack has shelves labeled A to Z. 2. The rule: each personâ€™s shoes go on the shelf matching the first letter of their name. 3. Mariaâ€™s shoes go on shelf M. Tomâ€™s shoes go on shelf T. 4. Mikeâ€™s shoes also belong on shelf M. Maria is already there, so Mikeâ€™s shoes go on the same shelf, next to Mariaâ€™s. 5. To find Mikeâ€™s shoes, you donâ€™t check all 26 shelves. You look at the name, see â€œMâ€, and go straight to shelf M. 6. On that shelf, you check the few pairs there until you find Mikeâ€™s.

Work Example:

Store the keys 10, 22, 31, 4, 15 in a table with m = 7 slots (0 to 6). |Key|Calculation|Slot|What Happens| |---|----|----|----| |10|10 Ã· 7 = 1 remainder 3|3|Slot 3 is empty, so store 10| |22|22 Ã· 7 = 3 remainder 1|1|Slot 1 is empty, so store 22| |31|31 Ã· 7 = 4 remainder 3|3|Collision with 10. Add 31 to the front of the list| |4|4 Ã· 7 = 0 remainder 4|4|Slot 4 is empty, so store 4| |15|15 Ã· 7 = 2 remainder 1|1|Collision with 22. Add 15 to the front of the list|

Visual



Hash table visual. https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/java/java-program-to-implement-hash-tables-chaining-with-doubly-linked-lists/

Question exercise & Answer:

A table has m = 5 slots (0 to 4) and uses h(k) = k mod 5 with chaining (new keys go to the front). Insert, in order: 12, 7, 20, 17, 9. 1. Which slot does each key go to? - 12 mod 5 = 2 â†’ slot 2 - 7 mod 5 = 2 â†’ slot 2 - 20 mod 5 = 0 â†’ slot 0 - 17 mod 5 = 2 â†’ slot 2 - 9 mod 5 = 4 â†’ slot 4

2. Which keys collide? - 12, 7, and 17 are in slot 2.

3. Search for 22. Which slot do you check, and is it on the table? - 22 mod 5 = 2, so check slot 2. Its list is 17, 7, 12, and 22 is not there. So 22 is not in the table.

4. Why canâ€™t we avoid collisions completely? - There are more possible keys than slots, so some keys must share a slot (Cormen p. 257).

References:

1. Cormen et al. Introduction to Algorithms, 3rd ed. Chapter 11 introduction, p. 253; Â§11.1 â€œDirect-address tablesâ€, p. 254; Â§11.2 â€œHash tablesâ€, pp. 256-258 (hash function, collisions, chaining, load factor); Â§11.3.1 â€œThe division methodâ€, p. 263. 2. https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/java/java-program-to-implement-hash-tables-chaining-with-doubly-linked-lists/

Outline:

A tree stores items in levels, like a company chart, with one item at the top and branches below. A binary search tree (BST) is a tree where smaller numbers go left and bigger numbers go right, so searching is fast. A trie is a tree for words, where each step down the tree is one letter.

Definition:

A tree is a set of items called nodes arranged in levels. The top node is the root, and a nodeâ€™s children are the nodes directly below it. A node with no children is a leaf. A binary tree gives each node at most two children. A binary search tree is a binary tree where, for every node, smaller keys are in its left branch and larger keys are in its right branch. A trie is a tree where each word is stored as a path of letters from the root, and a mark shows where a word ends.

Conditions for a Tree to be a Binary Search Tree

For a tree to be called a binary search, it should fulfill the following conditions: - All the nodes in the left subtree of any node contain smaller values and all the nodes in the right subtree of any node contain larger values. - Both the left and right subtrees of any node in the tree should themselves be a BST. This means that they should follow the BST rule. - A unique path exists from the root node to every other node.

Easy Analogy

- Tree: a company chart. The president is at the top, and the vice presidents and managers hang below. - BST: a road with signs at every junction: â€œsmaller numbers left, bigger numbers rightâ€. To find 6, you follow the signs and never check the whole tree. - Trie: phone autocomplete. When you type â€œcâ€, then â€œaâ€, the phone follows the letters one by one and suggests â€œcarâ€ or â€œcatâ€.

Basics terminologies used in BST:

- Children: The successor nodes of a node are called its children. - Parent: The predecessor node of a node is called its parent. - Root: The "beginning" node is called the root i.e. a node that has no parent. - leaf: A node that has no children is called a leaf.

Basic 3 operation: search, insertion and deletion in a binary search tree.

|Operations|Description|Best Case Time Complexity|Average Case Time Complexity|Worse Case Time Complexity| |--|--|--|--|--| |Search|This function is used to search a given key in BST.|O(log n)|O(log n)|O(n)| |Insertion|This function is used to insert values in a BST.|O(log n)|O(log n)|O(n)| |Deletion|This function is used to delete the specified node from a BST.|O(log n)|O(log n)|O(n)|

Work Example:

1. Build a BST. Insert 8, 3, 10, 1, 6 in this order. The first key becomes the root. Each next key walks down: smaller goes left, bigger goes right, until it finds an empty spot.

|Insert|Path|Result| |--|--|--| |8|Tree is empty|8 becomes the root| |3|3 < 8, go left|3 is left child of 8| |10|10 > 8, go right|10 is right child of 8| |1|1 < 8, left; 1 < 3, left|1 is left child of 3| |6|6 < 8, left; 6 > 3, right|6 is right child of 3|

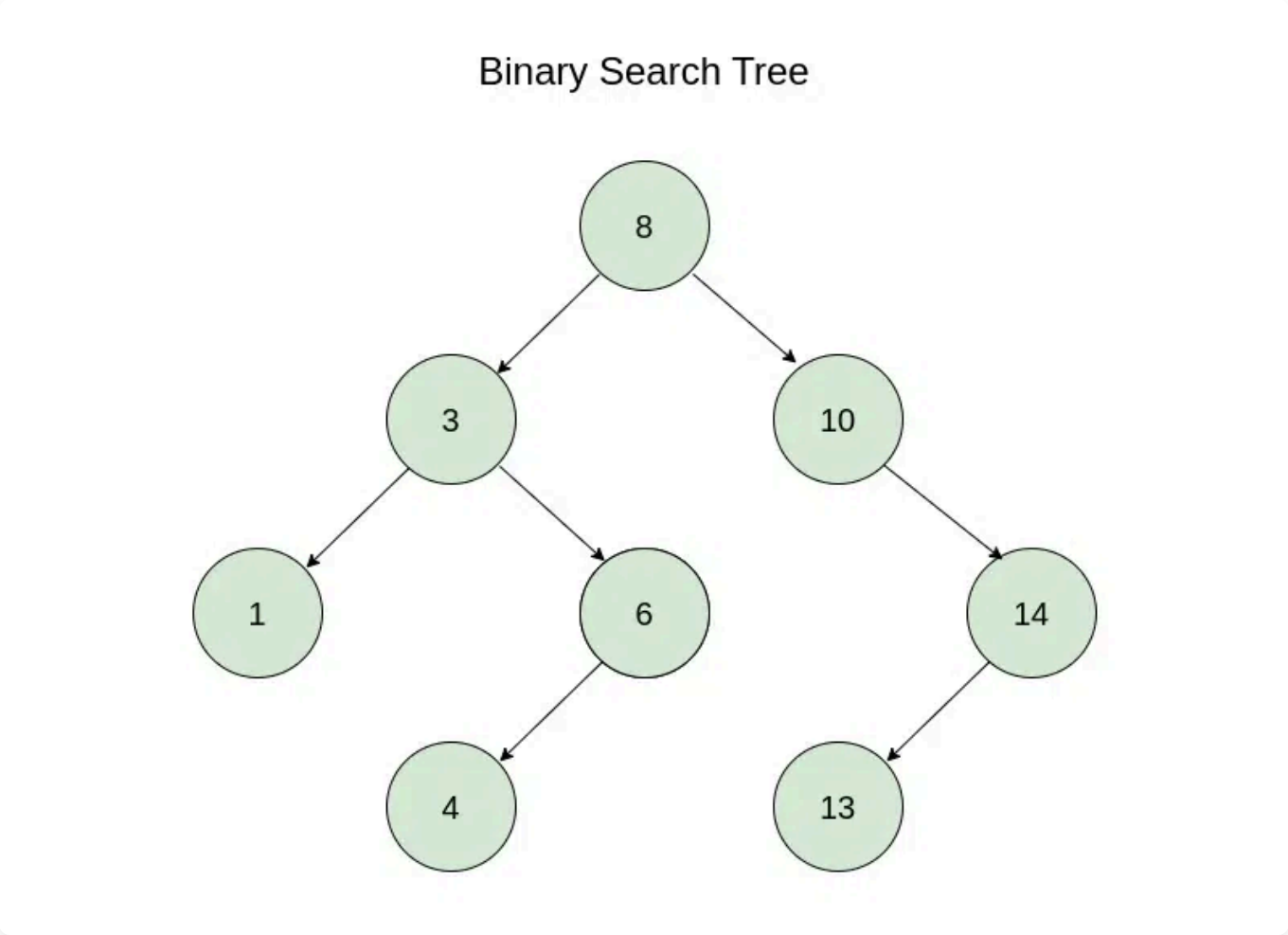
2. Search. - Search 6: start at 8, 6 is smaller so go left to 3, 6 is bigger so go right to 6. Found after 3 checks. - Search 7: 8 â†’ left to 3 â†’ right to 6 â†’ 7 is bigger, but 6 has no right child. Not

in the tree.

3. Read the tree in order - You get 1, 3, 6, 8, 10, which is sorted.

4. A trie - stores the words car, cat, do, dog. Search â€œcaâ€□: follow c â†’ a. There is no end mark on â€œaâ€□, so â€œcaâ€□ is not a word (only the start of one). Search â€œcabâ€□: after c â†’ a there is no â€œbâ€□ branch, so it is not in the trie.

Visual



BST Visual. https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/cpp/cpp-binary-search-tree/

Question exercise & Answer:

A tree has root A. Aâ€™s children are B and C. Bâ€™s children are D and E. 1. Name the leaves, the parent of D, and the sibling of B. - Leaves: C, D, E. Parent of D: B. Sibling of B: C.

2. Insert 5, 2, 8, 1, 4 into an empty BST, in this order. Then search for 4 and for 7. - 5 is the root. 2 goes left of 5. 8 goes right of 5. 1 goes left of 2. 4 goes right of 2. - Search 4: 5 â† left to 2 â† right to 4. Found after 3 checks. - Search 7: 5 â† right to 8 â† 7 is smaller, but 8 has no left child. Not in the tree.

3. List the keys of that tree in order (left branch, node, right branch). - 1, 2, 4, 5, 8.

5. In a trie holding â€œtoâ€, â€œteaâ€, and â€œtenâ€, is â€œteâ€ a word? - No. The path t â† e exists, but no word ends at â€œeâ€. It is only the start of â€œteaâ€ and â€œtenâ€.

6. What does the BST look like if you insert 1, 2, 3, 4 in that order, and why is that a problem? - Every new key is bigger, so it always goes right. The tree becomes one long chain, 1 â† 2 â† 3 â† 4. Searching then takes as many steps as a plain list. Cormen p. 286 says the same: the speed depends on the treeâ€™s height, and a chain of n nodes is the slow case.

References

1. Cormen et al. Introduction to Algorithms, 3rd ed. Chapter 12 â€œBinary Search Treesâ€: introduction p. 286; Â§12.1 pp. 286-288 (BST property, inorder walk); Â§12.2 pp. 289-290 (search); Â§12.3 p. 294 (insertion). 2. Sedgewick, R. and Wayne, K. Algorithms, 4th ed. Â§5.2 â€œTriesâ€ (for the trie part). 3. https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/cpp/cpp-binary-search-tree/

What is Artificial Intelligence (AI)?

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is a field of computer science focused on enabling computers and machines to do tasks that are commonly associated with intelligent beings. This includes, but not limited to, processing thoughts, decision-making, and creativity. In the 21st century, AI has become increasingly integrated into everyday life. Examples include AI-generated images, enemy behavior in video games, recommendation systems, and Large Language Models (LLMs) such as ChatGPT and Claude. These examples show how AI can be used across entertainment,

communication, and many other fields.

Components of Artificial Intelligence:

1. Machine Learning

Machine Learning is a subset of AI that focuses on making machines or algorithms "learn" patterns from training data and use them to make predictions or decisions. This "training" enables machine learning models to make decisions or predictions without explicit, hard-coded instructions. The core idea behind machine learning is that if you optimize a model's performance on a dataset of tasks that resemble the real-world problems it will be used for, through a process called model training, the model can make accurate predictions on the new data it is used for.

Examples: - Taobao Recommendations: Recommendation systems analyze, user behavior, inputs like browsing history, and other interactions to suggest products users might be interested in. - Spam Detection: Machine learning models learn patterns from examples of spam and legitimate emails to filter incoming messages.

Main types of machine learning algorithms:

1. Supervised Learning

Supervised Learning is when a model is trained on "Labelled Datasets" or in simpler terms, datasets that are categorized. The raw data that these algorithms use already have a predetermined label attached to them. For example, a model trained on labeled images of cats and dogs can learn patterns that help it classify a previously unknown image.

Supervised learning has two main categories: - **Classification**, predicts categorical outputs, meaning it assigns data into predefined classes like spam/non-spam emails or disease risk categories. These algorithms learn to map input features to discrete labels.

- **Regression**, predicts continuous values, such as house prices or product sales. It learns the relationship between input features and a numerical target variable.

2. Unsupervised Learning

Unsupervised learning is when a model is trained on unlabelled data. The algorithm has to find any hidden patterns, groups or relationships within the data on its own. It's mainly used for clustering, dimensionality reduction and data visualization. For example, a model analyzing customer purchasing behavior may identify groups of customers with similar shopping habits without being given predetermined customer categories.

Unsupervised learning has three main categories : - **Clustering**, groups data points into clusters based on their similarity. This technique is useful for identifying patterns and relationships in data without the need for labeled examples. - **Dimensionality Reduction Techniques**, reduces the number of features while preserving important information. - **Association Rule Learning**, technique for discovering relationships between items in a dataset. It identifies rules that indicate the presence of one item implies the presence of another item with a specific probability.

3. Reinforcement Learning

Reinforcement learning is when a model is trained to make a sequence of decisions through trial and error. The system or we call the agent, interacts with the environment, receives feedback in the form of rewards or penalties and learns optimal actions over time. For example, an AI agent learning to play chess gets positive feedback for good moves and negative for poor ones. Over time, it improves its strategies through repeated games.

Types of Reinforcement Learning : - Positive Reinforcement, rewarding desired behavior (e.g., giving points for correct answers). - Negative Reinforcement, removing negative outcomes to encourage good actions (e.g., turning off a buzzer after the right move).

2. Deep Learning

Deep learning is a subset of machine learning that builds multilayered neural networks, called deep neural networks, that more closely simulate the complex decision-making power of the human brain.

Neural networks consist of interconnected artificial neurons organized into layers. In a deep neural network, information passes through multiple layers, where mathematical transformations allow the model to learn increasingly complex patterns.

The deep learning process consists of three layers, the input layer receives data, the hidden layers transform the information, and the output layer generates a prediction or other result. Through training, the network adjusts itself to improve its performance.

What is Connectionist AI?

Connectionist AI is an approach to artificial intelligence that models human behavior through networks of interconnected artificial neurons or processing units we call nodes. Instead of relying on hard-coded rules or instructions, connectionist models learn patterns from data by adjusting the strengths of connections between neurons.

Symbolic vs Connectionist AI

Symbolic AI and Connectionist AI are two approaches to developing artificial intelligence. They differ mainly in how they represent information and solve problems. Symbolic AI uses rules and logical structures to solve problems based on the principle of warrantable knowledge. Connectionist, or neural network AI is based on the structure of the human brain, processes data and adapts easily to new data as it relies on patterns.

For example, when trying to recognize a cat using symbolic AI, hard-coded rules will be used to give categorisations or characteristics to a cat, like a cat has four legs, two ears, or other feline characteristics. If these conditions are fulfilled, the AI will recognise it as a cat. In contrast, connectionist AI can only recognize a cat once it has been trained sufficiently to distinguish what is a cat. It has to be trained on labeled cat and non-cat images, learning patterns in the data that help it distinguish cats from other objects. This is just one among the many differences between these two.

| **Aspect** | **Symbolic AI** | **Connectionist AI** | | :--- | :----: | ---: | | Knowledge Representation | Uses explicit symbols and rules | Uses connections and weights in networks | | Transparency | High, interpretable and traceable | Low, hard to interpret | | Reasoning Ability | Excels in logical reasoning and problem-solving | Excels in pattern recognition and prediction | | Scalability | Struggles with large, complex datasets | Scales well with large datasets | | Flexibility | Less flexible and adaptable | Highly adaptable through training | | Resource Requirements | Less resource-intensive | Requires significant computational resources | | Risk of Overfitting | Lower risk | Higher risk |

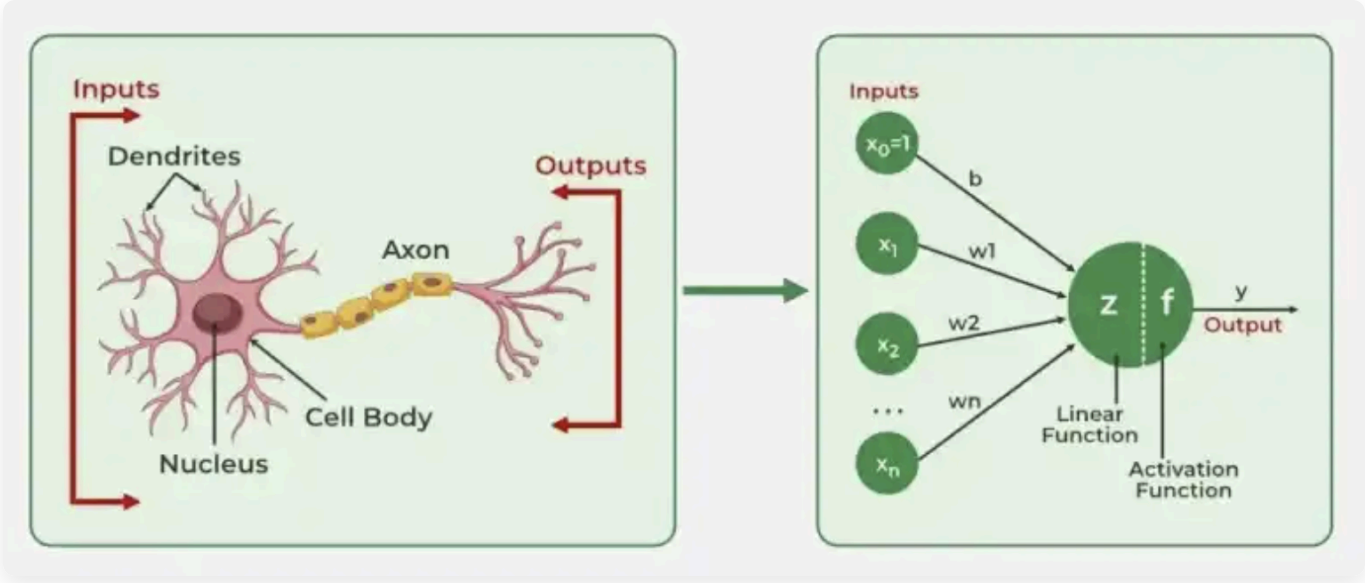
*Overfitting = Cases when an AI model fits training data too closely, instead of learning the underlying patterns behind the data.

In present day, hybrid forms of these AI have been created, called Neuro-Symbolic AI. This combines neural networks with symbolic reasoning to tackle tasks like visual question answering, where understanding complex scenes and answering questions requires both pattern recognition and logical reasoning.

References: - https://www.ibm.com/think/topics/artificial-intelligence - https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/machine-learning/types-of-machine-learning/ - https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/deep-learning/introduction-deep-learning/ - https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/deep-learning/neural-networks-a-beginners-guide/ - https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/artificial-intelligence/difference-between-symbolic-and-connectionist-ai/

Artificial Neural Network (ANN)

Artificial Neural Networks (ANNs) are the fundamental building blocks of deep learning systems and connectionist AI. It consists of interconnected artificial neurons organized into layers. Each neuron receives inputs, combines them using weights and a bias, and applies an activation function to produce an output.



The idea behind neural networks themselves comes from human biology and is inspired by the brain. This structure can be compared to biological neurons, with dendrites receiving signals as inputs, the cell body processing them, and the axon transmitting signals to other neurons. Similarly, artificial neurons receive inputs, process them, and pass their outputs to other neurons. However, artificial neural networks are only simplified mathematical models and do not reproduce the full complexity of biological neurons.

How does an Artificial Neuron Work?

We can think of an artificial neuron as a small decision-maker. It receives information, processes it, and produces an output. For example, when identifying an image, a neuron might respond more strongly to certain patterns in the image.

Each neuron receives inputs, such as numbers or pixel values, from the input data or other neurons. Each input has a **weight**, which determines how strongly it influences the neuron's result. The neuron combines these weighted inputs with a value called a **bias**, then applies an **activation function** to determine its output.

Neurons are organized into layers, each with a different role: - Input Layer: Receives the original data, such as the pixel values of an image. - Hidden Layers: Process the information and learn patterns, such as edges, shapes, or other features in an image. - Output Layer: Produces the final

result, such as predicting whether an image contains a cat or a dog.

Information passes from one layer to the next, with each layer transforming the information it receives. You can think of this process as gradually assembling puzzle pieces: early layers may identify simple patterns, while later layers combine them into more complex features. Through training, the network adjusts its weights and biases to improve its predictions.

How do these networks learn (Simple)?

Neural networks learn through training, which involves adjusting their parameters to improve their performance. This process generally involves three stages: - Input Computation: Data is fed into the network. - Output Generation: Based on the current parameters, the network generates an output. - Iterative Refinement: The network refines its output by adjusting weights and biases, gradually improving its performance on diverse tasks.

By repeating this process across many training examples, the network can gradually learn patterns that help it make better predictions on new data.

Next: - Add mathematical concepts of an artificial neuron

References: - https://www.ibm.com/think/topics/artificial-intelligence - https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/machine-learning/types-of-machine-learning/ - https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/deep-learning/introduction-deep-learning/ - https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/deep-learning/neural-networks-a-beginners-guide/ - https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/artificial-intelligence/difference-between-symbolic-and-connectionist-ai/ 2.3 Neural Network Architecture

A neural network takes input data and passes it through layers of connected nodes to make a prediction.

2.3.1 Input Layer

The input layer is where data enters the network. It receives raw feature values from a dataset. For example, to predict house prices using three features: House size in square feet Number of

bedrooms Age of the house in years

Activity 1: Guess Task Type

â€‹Imagine you are training an Artificial Intelligence (AI) model. Determine whether each scenario below represents a Regression or Classification task:

1.â€‹Predicting tomorrow's weather temperature in degrees Celsius example: (28.5Â°C).

2.â€‹Detecting whether an incoming email is "Spam" or "Not Spam".

2.3.2 Hidden Layers

Hidden layers sit between the input and output layers. They perform math steps to find patterns between features. Instead of looking at size and age separately, a hidden node can combine them to measure something deeper, like overall wear and tear or space efficiency, before making a final prediction.

2.3.3 Output Layer

The output layer gives the final calculated result. The type of result depends on the task: Regression Tasks: Predicts a continuous number (estimating a house price of $250,000). Classification Tasks: Predicts a category probability (a 90% chance of being a cat and a 10% chance of being a dog).

2.3.4 Weights and Biases

Weight: A number that multiplies an input to show its importance. A higher weight gives an input a bigger impact on the final answer. Bias: An extra value added to the calculation that helps shift the output so the network can fit the data better.

2.3.5 Activation Functions

Activation functions add curves and non-linear logic to the network. This allows the model to learn complex relationships instead of simple straight lines. Key types include: ReLU: Turns negative numbers into zero, but keeps positive numbers the same. Sigmoid: Squashes any

number into a value between 0 and 1, which represents a probability.

Activity 2:Check Quiz

1.â€‹Which component of a neural network converts negative numbers into zero while leaving positive numbers unchanged? â€‹A) Output Layer â€‹B) ReLU â€‹C) Bias â€‹D) Input Layer

2.â€‹What is the primary function of "Weights" in a neural network? â€‹A) Shifting the calculation curve to better fit the data. â€‹B) Storing raw input features directly from the dataset. â€‹C) Showing how important a specific input feature is to the final prediction. â€‹D) Counting the total number of features.

ACTIVITY 1 ANSWER KEY

1.â€‹Regression (predicts a continuous number).

2.â€‹Classification (predicts a category or class probability).

ACTIVITY 2 ANSWER KEY

1. B (ReLU sets all negative values to zero while leaving positive values unchanged so the model can handle non-linear patterns). 2. C (Weights act as importance multipliers that determine how strongly each input feature influences the final prediction). 2.4 Mechanics of Neural Network Training

Training is the process of updating weights and biases so the model's guesses get closer to the real values.

2.4.1 Training Step-by-Step

1.Forward Propagation: Input data flows forward through the network to make a guess ï¼ˆpredicting a house costs $300,000).

2.Loss Function Calculation: The loss function measures how far the guess is from the true value. If the real price is $250,000, the error is 50,000.

3.Backpropagation: The network works backward from the error. It calculates how much each weight contributed to the 50,000 error.

4.Gradient Descent and Learning Rate: The network updates its weights to reduce future errors using the learning rate. Too Large Learning Rate: Takes steps that are too big and misses the best answer. Too Small Learning Rate: Takes tiny steps and requires thousands of slow updates to learn.

Activity 1: Put the Steps in Order

1.â€‹Rearrange these 4 steps into the correct order of how a neural network learns: A) Backpropagation (Working backward to see which weights caused the error) â€‹B) Forward Propagation (Passing inputs forward to make a guess) â€‹C) Gradient Descent (Updating weights using the learning rate) â€‹D) Loss Function Calculation (Measuring how wrong the guess was)

Activity 2: Check Quiz

1.â€‹What happens if a neural network uses a learning rate that is set too large? â€‹A) The network learns instantly in one step. â€‹B) The network takes steps that are too big and overshoots the best answer. â€‹C) The network takes millions of tiny steps and learns very slowly. â€‹D) The network stops making predictions entirely.

2.â€‹Which step in neural network training specifically measures the difference between the model's guess and the actual target value? â€‹A) Loss Function Calculation â€‹B) Backpropagation â€‹C) Forward Propagation â€‹D) Learning Rate Tuning

ACTIVITY 1 ANSWER KEY: â€‹1.B-D-A-C (network must first guess, calculate its error, trace that error backward, and finally adjust its weights to improve next time).

ACTIVITY 2 ANSWER KEY: 1.B (learning rate that is too high causes step sizes to be too large, causing the algorithm to jump over and miss the lowest error point). 2.A (The loss function evaluates model accuracy by calculating a mathematical score of how far the prediction is from the real value). 2.5 Model Evaluation and Generalization

After training, you test how well the network works on new,unseen data.

2.5.1 Dataset Splitting

To keep testing honest, the dataset is split into three separate parts: Training Set (~70%): Used directly to train weights and biases.

Validation Set (~15%): Used during training to tweak settings and prevent the model from memorizing.

Test Set (~15%): Saved for the very end to check real-world accuracy.

2.5.2 Common Training Mistakes

Overfitting: The model gets high accuracy on training data, but low accuracy on test data because it memorized noise instead of learning main trends.

Underfitting: The model gets poor accuracy on both training and test data because it is too simple to learn anything useful.

2.5.3 Classification Metrics

To measure classification performance, these metrics look at correct and incorrect predictions:

Accuracy: The percentage of total correct predictions.

Precision: Out of all positive predictions, how many were actually correct.

Recall: Out of all real positive items, how many did the model find.

F1-Score: The balance between precision and recall, best used when data classes are uneven (detecting rare fraud cases).

Activity 1: Match the Training Mistake

â€‹Read the scenarios below and identify whether they describe Overfitting or Underfitting:

â€‹-An AI model scores 98% on its practice questions (training data), but fails miserably with a

45% score on the real exam using brand-new questions.

-â€‹An AI model scores 50% on practice questions and 50% on the real exam because the model is too basic to grasp the rules.

â€‹Activity 2: Concept Check Quiz

â€‹Which dataset portion is safely locked away until the very end of development to test how well the model works on completely real-world, unseen data? â€‹A) Training Set â€‹B) Validation Set â€‹C) Test Set â€‹D) Noise Set

â€‹Which metric should you use when your dataset has very uneven classes, such as detecting rare medical conditions or credit card fraud? â€‹A) Accuracy â€‹B) F1-Score â€‹C) Dataset Splitting â€‹D) Underfitting

ACTIVITY 1 ANSWER KEY

â€‹1.Overfitting (Overfitting happens when a model memorizes specific training data instead of learning general rules).

2.â€‹Underfitting (Underfitting happens when a model is too simple to learn anything useful from the data).

ACTIVITY 2 ANSWER KEY

1. C) test set (The test set is kept completely untouched until the end to give an honest measure of real-world accuracy).

â€‹2. B) F1-Score (The F1-score balances both precision and recall, making it reliable when dealing with uneven data classes).

2.6 Major Neural Network Types

Connectionist AI relies on Artificial Neural Networks (ANNs), which model cognition using layers of interconnected processing units (artificial neurons) that adjust weighted connections through

data.

Major Types of Neural Networks

* Feed Forward Networks (FNNs)

To put it simply Feed forward Network is like an asembly line. It is the most basic type of neural network. Where information only moves in one direction, forward. Data enters through an "input layer", passes through one or more "hidden layers" that process the information, and exits as a final decision through an "output layer". Feedforward Neural Network are best for: Simple tasks like identifying if an email is spam or predicting a price based on a spreadsheet of basic data.

* Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs)

To put it simply Convolutional Neural Networks is like scanning a picture with a magnifying glass. CNNs are designed specifically to look at grids of data, like images by scanning small chunks of the image piece by piece. It looks for basic edges and shapes first, then pieces them together. Convulutional Neural Networks are best for: Facial recognition, identifying diseases in medical x-ray, and computer vision for self driving cars.

* Recurrent Neural Networks (RNNs)

To put it simply Recurrent Neural Networks is like reading a book and remembering the last sentence you read. Standard networks forget everything they just did the moment they started a new job ask. RNN solves this problem problem by using a built in "memory" loop that lets them remember previous inputs, so they can understand context in a sequence of data over time. Recurrent Neural Networks are best for: Speech recognition (like alexa, siri, or google), translating sentences between languages, and predicting the weather.

* Transformers

To put it simply Transformers is like looking at a whole paragraph at once and instantly understanding how every word relates to the other. Transformers are the modern heavyweight of the ai world. Transformers use an "attention mechanism." This allows the networks to look at an entire sequence of data simultaneously and figure out which part are the most important,

making them incredibly fast and smart with language. Transformers are best for Large Language Models (LLMs) like Chat GPT, Gemini, and advanced text generation.

* Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs)

To put it simply Generative Adversarial Networks is like an art forger and a police detective. GANs are actually two networks competing against eachother. Where one network (The forger) tries to generate fake data, like a realistic picture of a human face and the other one (the detective) tries to spot whether the iamhe is real or fake. They constantly learn from eachother until the forger creates images the detective couldn't tell the difference between its real or fake. Since its so lifelike. Generative Adversarial Networks are best for: Creating AI art, deepfakes, generating realistic video game assets, and enhancing low resolution images.

* Autoencoders

To put it simply Autoencoders is like packing and unpacking a perfectly organized suitcase. An autoencoders learns how to compress (encode) data down to its most essential, bare bones information to save space, and then learns how to rebuild (decode) it back to its original form. Autoencoders are best for: Removing background noises from audio or grainy spots from photos, and detecting anomalies (like credit card fraud) by noticing when data doesn't "unpack" normally.

* Long Short-Term Memory Networks (LSTMs)

To put it simply Long Short-Term Memory Networks is like taking detailed notes so you don't forget the beginning of a long lecture. LSTMs are an upgraded, highly popular version of RNNs. LSTMs have a special internal "gates" that actively decide what information is important enough to keep in long-term memory and what to throw away. Long Short-Term Memory Network are best for: Complex language translation, generating text, and analyzing time sensitive data like stock market trends.

* Self-Organizing Maps (SOMs)

To put it simply Self-Organizing Maps is like sorting a massive, messy pile of laundry by putting similar colors and fabrics next to eachother. SOMs are given chaotic, unlabeled data and left alone to figure it out. They organize the data into a 2D map where similar items are grouped

close together. Self-Organizing Maps are best for: Customer segmentation (grouping similar types pf shoppers together), identifying weather patterns, and visualizing complex data.

* Spiking Neural Networks (SNNs)

To put it simply Spiking Neural Networks is like sending a message using flashes of flashlight in the dark. SNNs are the closest networks to how biological human brains actually work. Instead of processing numbers constantly, SNNs only send a signal (a "spike") when they gather enough information to reach a certain threshold. Because they aren't "on" all the time. Spiking Neural Networks are best for: Extremely low power AI chips, robotics, and advanced brain computer interference.

* Modular Neural Networks

To put it simply Modular Neural Networks is like a large company specialized departments. Instead of building one massive network to solve a huge problem, a modular network links several smaller separate networks together. Each small network is an expert at one spesific task, and a "manager" network combines their findings to make a final decision. Modular Neural Networks are best for: Highly complex systems like self-driving cars (where one module watches for pedestrians, another reads signs, and another controls the steering wheel).

Exercise 2.6 1. This networks is like sending a message using flashes of flashlight in the dark. What network type is it?

a. SNNs

b. SOMs

c. FNNs

d. CNNs

e. RNNs

2. What's FNNs stand for?

a. Federal News Networks

b. False Nearest Neighbors

c. Financial News Networks

d. Feed Forward Networks

e. Fuzzy Neural Networks

3. What's Modular Neural Networks like?

a. A large company specialized departments.

b. Sorting a massive pile of laundry by putting similar fabric and colors near eachother.

c. Packing and unpacking a perfectly organized suitcase.

d. Reading a book and remembering the last sentence you read.

e. An art forger and a police detective

4. How does Convolutional Neural Networks works?

a. Using a built in "memory" loop that lets them remember previous inputs.

b. Linking several smaller seperate networks together.

c. Send a "spike" when they gather enough information to reach a certain threshold.

d. Organizing data into a 2D map where similar items are grouped close together.

e. Scanning small chunks of the image piece by piece. Then pieces them together.

5. If you want to identify weather patterns what's the best Major Neural Network Types to use?

a. SOMs

b. Modular Neural Networks

c. RNNs

d. Autoencoders

e. Federal News Networks